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TIMING AND TEMPO

How to actually practice with a *metronome*.

Playing along with a click measures how well you follow a sound. Testing against it measures your time. This is how to run the second one.

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A metronome is a measuring instrument, not an accompanist. Playing along with it mostly tests how well you follow a sound, which is a different skill from keeping time. The version that changes your playing is the opposite: you keep the time, and the click checks it. Make the click sparse enough that the timekeeping is genuinely yours, put the passage against it, and listen to the gap between your note and the click. Where that gap opens is the fault. A metronome does not make you steady. It makes unsteadiness audible.

What a click actually reveals

A metronome does one thing: it produces an event at a fixed interval. It has no opinion about your playing and no way to correct you. All of the information sits in the distance between the click and your note, and that distance carries three readings.

- **Direction.** Are you consistently in front of the click, or consistently behind it? The two have different causes and different fixes, and guessing wrong costs you the week.
- **Location.** Which beat, which bar, which side of a chord change. A timing problem that is really one transition is a small job. A timing problem everywhere is a different job.
- **Shape.** Does the gap grow steadily from the top, or open in one spot and close again? Steady growth is a tempo you cannot hold. A spike is a passage you cannot play yet.

A click on every beat gives you almost none of this. It re-anchors you four times a bar, so you never drift far enough for the drift to be visible. That is why quarter notes under a strummed song feel reassuring and teach so little: they confirm you can stay within a beat of a reference, which you already could.

Subdivision is the part you are missing

Time is not the beats but the space between them, and that space is where almost everything you play lives. With the click on the beat, the beat is the only place you have a reference. Offbeats, sixteenths, the back half of a strum pattern, the moment you release a chord: all unsupervised.

So supervise it yourself. Count the subdivision out loud while you play, in whatever unit the passage moves in. Out loud matters, because counting in your head quietly stops when a bar gets hard, and the bar that stops you counting is the bar you were looking for.

Match the click to the passage, not to the smallest note in it. A click on every sixteenth under a sixteenth-note figure removes the thing you are building, which is your own even division of the beat. Click the eighths and let your hands own the sixteenths.

Move the click to expose your real time-keeping

Beats two and four

Halve the metronome tempo and hear each click as the backbeat. For a piece at 120, set the metronome to 60 and count four beats with the clicks landing on two and four. Beats one and three are yours to place now. Getting in takes a few attempts, because starting against a click that is not beat one is genuinely harder, and drift shows up within a bar or two rather than never: a rushed beat one has nothing propping it up.

Beat one only

Quarter the tempo. At 120 that is a click at 30, one per bar in common time, near the bottom of the range on many metronomes. You are keeping three beats out of four, so one rushed bar puts your downbeat audibly in front of the click instead of merely feeling wrong. This is where most players find their time is fine in the easy bars and moves everywhere else.

Bars with no click at all

Sparser than one click per bar needs a metronome that can mute bars, a gap or silence setting if yours has one. Two bars of click, two bars of nothing, repeating. Play through the silence and find out whether you land back on the click or in front of it. For two bars there is no reference at all, and the verdict arrives at once.

The click on the offbeat

The hardest placement, and it tests what the others cannot: whether your subdivision is even. Keep the metronome at the quarter-note tempo, count one and two and over it, then flip the count so the clicks land on the ands rather than the numbers. It will invert on you the first several times, snapping back until the click sounds like a downbeat again. That inversion is the test: if your eighths are uneven, the flip has nothing steady to sit on.

What playing ahead and dragging feel like

Playing ahead

The click seems to arrive a moment after you rather than with you, as though the metronome had slowed down. The passage feels urgent and the sensation is one of leaning. Rushing shows up in the easy bars, in the bar after a difficult one, and anywhere the music gets louder. Relief speeds people up as reliably as nerves do.

Dragging

The click seems to pull away, and playing feels like chasing something. Dragging sits in the physically expensive bar: the stretch, the barre, the position shift, the first chord after a change your fretting hand has not finished making. It also appears wherever you are still deciding what comes next, because deciding takes time the bar does not have.

The combination that costs you

The common pattern is both at once. Rush into the hard bar, drag through it, come out in front again. Across a take the errors cancel, so the average looks fine while the take sounds wrong. Nobody hears an average. They hear the two places where the pulse moved.

One cheap test for direction, once the click is sparse: turn it down until it is only just audible. Land exactly on it and your attack swallows the click, so it seems to vanish. Land off it and you hear two separate events, and their order tells you which way you went.

Tempo is a measurement, not a target

A number on a metronome means nothing by itself. What makes it a measurement is the condition attached, so write that down beside it. Bars nine to twelve, 84 BPM, three passes in a row, cold, no missed notes and no stopping. That is a reading. Just 84 is a memory, and memory rounds in your favor.

Cold is the load-bearing word: first thing in the session, no run-up, no eight attempts. Best of eight is a ceiling, and a ceiling is not what shows up when you play for someone. What you can repeat cold is a floor, and the floor is the only number worth building on.

A number with no condition drifts upward on its own. The tempo you hit once on the twentieth try is your tempo by Thursday, and every session after it is built on a coincidence.

With a real floor and a target, the distance between them is a plan rather than a wish. The [tempo ladder builder](#) turns those two numbers into an ordered set of sessions: every increase capped, some sessions repeating a tempo instead of adding to it, and at least one that drops below the top speed and climbs back. Reaching a tempo once and owning it are different events.

When the target refuses to arrive however patiently you climb, the ceiling is usually not made of tempo. [What actually limits speed](#) is worth reading before you turn the number up again.

Four drills, each with a pass condition

Each takes a few minutes and returns a yes or a no. A drill with no pass condition is time near a metronome.

1. **The cold three.** First thing in the session, no warm-up: three consecutive clean passes at one tempo. *Pass:* three in a row, not three out of five. Every other number depends on this one.
2. **The silent bar.** Two bars of click, two bars muted, repeating. *Pass:* four cycles where the click returns exactly where you expected it.
3. **The one-question listen.** Record thirty seconds against a sparse click, then listen back for one thing: ahead or behind, and where. *Pass:* you can name a bar.
4. **The handover.** Play the passage with the click, then immediately without it, then a third time with it back on. *Pass:* the click comes back roughly where your playing left it. A large jump means the click was carrying you.

Run them on GuitarHub's free [tuner and metronome](#), which keeps a steady four-beat click at any tempo you set. When you want a verdict on every attack, four free Advanced Lab drills time each hit against the grid through your microphone: [syncopated sixteenths](#), [quarter-note triplets](#), [the shift from triplets to sixteenths](#), and [dotted-eighth displacement](#).

When not to use a metronome

A click answers one narrow question. Pointed at a different one it teaches something you then have to undo.

- **When the problem is not timing.** Tone, vibrato, whether a bend arrives in tune, the balance inside a voicing. A click holds no information about any of them and pulls your attention off what you sat down to fix.
- **When the motion does not exist yet.** A click is a deadline. Give one to a hand that has not made the movement and you get a tense approximation you then have to practice your way out of. Build the motion slowly and freely. Add the clock once it repeats.
- **When the music is not in strict time.** A rubato intro, a free ending, a passage meant to breathe. Practicing those to a click removes the thing they are.
- **When you are playing with a recording or with people.** The recording is the reference, and so is the drummer. A click running against a human is an argument you cannot win.
- **When you can no longer play the piece without one.** That is a dependency, and the handover drill is how you catch it. The cure is not more click. It is the sparse settings above, in order.

- **When you are playing for the pleasure of it.** Not every session is practice, and a measuring instrument is poor company.

Where the click sits in a week

A metronome is one tool inside a session, not the session. It belongs to the moments when you are testing something specific and want an outside opinion, which is a narrow slice of the week. [The GuitarHub method](#) puts that slice in order: measure where you are, shrink the problem, put it back under pressure, then record and compare. A click earns its place in the first and third.

Practice moves when an attempt has a specific target and honest feedback attached, which is what a sparse click supplies. There is more on [what that looks like at the instrument](#), and on [how to spend a practice hour](#). Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) covers the scheduling side.

One last thing a click cannot do. It tells you that you are late, not why, and the why is almost always somewhere else: a chord shape your hand reaches for a beat too late, a pick stroke starting on the wrong side of the string, a breath you stopped taking four bars ago. Naming that cause is a separate job. Strumly's guide to [practicing with an AI coach](#) covers what that kind of feedback is good for and where it stops.

AI Instructions